Digital Social Work Practice

Learner guide | SWP-031 | School of Community & Macro Practice

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Digital Social Work Practice. By the end of the course, you should be able to use digital tools and digital service channels in ways that advance access, protect privacy, and preserve accountable human professional judgement.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Use digital tools and digital service channels in ways that advance access, protect privacy, and preserve accountable human professional judgement.
- Apply the key ideas from Digital inclusion and service design.
- Apply the key ideas from Information governance and secure practice.
- Apply the key ideas from Telepractice, AI, and professional accountability.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Digital inclusion and service design	digital exclusion, accessibility, participation, community co-design, device and connectivity constraints, and non-digital alternatives	10 to 15 minutes
2. Information governance and secure practice	purpose limitation, informed consent, minimum necessary information, secure communication, records, retention, incident reporting, and local legal requirements	10 to 15 minutes
3. Telepractice, AI, and professional accountability	role and boundary setting, suitability and risk checks, bias and error awareness, human review, transparency, documentation, supervision, and escalation	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Digital inclusion and service design

This module focuses on digital exclusion, accessibility, participation, community co-design, device and connectivity constraints, and non-digital alternatives. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Digital exclusion
- Accessibility
- Participation
- Community co-design
- Device
- Connectivity constraints
- Non-digital alternatives

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of digital inclusion and service design in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of digital exclusion, accessibility, participation, community co-design, device and connectivity constraints, and non-digital alternatives. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through digital inclusion and service design safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Information governance and secure practice

This module focuses on purpose limitation, informed consent, minimum necessary information, secure communication, records, retention, incident reporting, and local legal requirements. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Purpose limitation
- Informed consent
- Minimum necessary information
- Secure communication
- Records
- Retention
- Incident reporting
- Local legal requirements

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of information governance and secure practice in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of purpose limitation, informed consent, minimum necessary information, secure communication, records, retention, incident reporting, and local legal requirements. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through information governance and secure practice safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Telepractice, AI, and professional accountability

This module focuses on role and boundary setting, suitability and risk checks, bias and error awareness, human review, transparency, documentation, supervision, and escalation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Role
- Boundary setting
- Suitability
- Risk checks
- Bias
- Error awareness
- Human review
- Transparency
- Documentation
- Supervision
- Escalation

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of telepractice, ai, and professional accountability in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of role and boundary setting, suitability and risk checks, bias and error awareness, human review, transparency, documentation, supervision, and escalation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through telepractice, ai, and professional accountability safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: digital inclusion.
- Review the distinction between: informed consent.
- Review the distinction between: minimum necessary information.
- Review the distinction between: secure communication.
- Review the distinction between: AI-assisted practice.
- Review the distinction between: human oversight.
- Review the distinction between: accountability.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.